construction of a trans-Afghanistan railway linked to Herat, and if India is hindered by less robust infrastructure links, the result could be that India sees its own strategic and economic interests in Afghanistan constricted. The regions to India's west could join the Bay of Bengal to India's east, the Himalayas to India's north, and the Indian Ocean to India's south as arenas of China's creeping encirclement of India.

India has been handicapped in the contest to shape Afghanistan's post-American future by Pakistan's refusal to allow Indian goods bound for Afghanistan to transit Pakistan. India aspires to limit Pakistan's influence and presence in post-America Afghanistan and nudge that country toward a secular and pluralistic government friendly to India and its interests. India has invested considerable diplomatic energy and money to build the capacities of the Afghan government in its struggles against the Pakistan-backed Taliban. India has faced a handicap in its Afghan effort due to its lack of contiguity with Afghanistan. India has sought to overcome this effort by securing from Iran an agreement to build the Chahbaharto-Delaram transit corridor. India scuppered the Chabahar project as it manoeuvred toward a strategic partnership with the United States circa 2003 but revived it during Modi's May 2016 visit to Tehran. Revival of the Chabahar project dovetails with India's partnership with Russia and Iran to create a North–South corridor connecting southern Russia via Iran with the Indian Ocean littoral.

China has proposed the integration of the India–Iran Chabahar project and the China–Pakistan Economic Corridor. Thus far, India has shown little enthusiasm for such a merger. It may be that New Delhi prefers a transit arrangement with Afghanistan independent of China and its quasi-ally Pakistan. Partnership with Iran and Russia, both of which may share some of India's apprehensions about China's growing influence in southwest Asia, may be preferable to giving Beijing a voice in Indian efforts to shape Afghanistan's future.